Lesson 7 — The Bench by the Stairs

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — modals: can, could, should, must, have to

Level: B1 (seventh step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the present perfect continuous

Lesson 5 taught have / has + been + -ing, for how long something has been going on. Two lines to remind you:

I / YOU / WE / THEY	HAVE BEEN WORKING
he / she / it	has been working

New this time: some verbs never take the continuous at all.

A verb that describes an action can be continuous. A verb that describes a state — something that simply is the case, with nothing happening — cannot:

STATE VERB	SAY THIS	NEVER THIS
be	The bench has been there for two years.	has been being
know	She has known about the fault for a week.	has been knowing
own	The college has owned that laptop since 2019.	has been owning
mean	I have meant to ask you for days.	have been meaning
need	It has needed a new fan all year.	has been needing
belong	That screwdriver has belonged to the bench since the start.	has been belonging

The family is small and worth learning as a list: be, have (= own), *know, understand, believe, need, want, like, love, hate, mean, belong, cost, seem. With these, use the present perfect simple* even when you are talking about how long.

A warning: a few of them change meaning and then they can be continuous. I am having a problem is an action (experiencing), not ownership. She is thinking about it is an action; I think it is broken is an opinion, and an opinion is a state.

Quick practice. Simple or continuous?

1. The bench _____ (be) under the stairs for two years.
2. They _____ (keep) a log since the first week.
3. She _____ (know) about that fault for a month.
4. He _____ (clean) fans all afternoon.

Now the modals. A modal verb sits in front of another verb and changes what the sentence is doing: how certain it is, how possible, how necessary, how permitted. The whole family behaves the same way, which is the good news.

3.1 How they work — three rules, no exceptions

RULE	RIGHT	WRONG
No to after the modal	She can change a screen.	she can to change
No -s for he / she / it	He must unplug it.	he musts unplug
Negative and question need no do	Can you open it? / You must not open it.	do you can open

The only one that breaks the pattern is have to, which is not really a modal at all: it is the ordinary verb have, so it does take do, does and did — Do you have to be quick?

3.2 Ability, and permission: can and could

	EXAMPLE
Ability now	She can change a screen in forty minutes.
Ability in the past	She could not work without a laptop.
Possibility	A capacitor can hold a charge for days.
Permission	Anyone in the college can bring a machine to them.
Asking politely	Could I leave it here until Thursday?

Could is the past of can, and it is also the polite present. Both are normal; the sentence tells you which.

3.3 Advice: should

Should is the weakest of them, and the most useful. It gives advice, not an order, and the speaker knows you may do otherwise:

> You should touch the metal frame first.
>
> A machine under warranty should not be opened.
>
> Should I take the battery out?

should have + past participle looks back at advice that was not taken: They should have checked the fan first. They did not, and now they know.

3.4 Necessity: must and have to

Both mean the thing is necessary. They differ in where the necessity comes from, and the difference is real:

	WHERE IT COMES FROM	EXAMPLE
must	the speaker, or a rule the speaker owns	You must unplug the machine. — it is on her list

	WHERE IT COMES FROM	EXAMPLE
have to	a fact, a law, somebody else	She had to learn, because nobody else would.

In the past, must has no past tense: you must use had to for both. Yesterday I had to replace the fan, never yesterday I must replace.

3.5 The one that catches everybody

must not and do not have to are opposites, not synonyms:

	MEANING	EXAMPLE
must not	it is forbidden — do not do it	You must not open a power supply.
do not have to	it is not necessary — do it or do not	You do not have to be quick.

Read those two lines twice. You must not be quick and you do not have to be quick are two completely different instructions, and the passage uses both kinds within four lines of each other.

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Choose the right modal:

1. You _____ unplug the machine before you open it. (rule on the list)
2. She _____ change a screen in forty minutes. (ability)
3. You _____ touch the metal frame first. (advice)
4. She _____ learn, because nobody else would do it. (past necessity)
5. _____ I leave the laptop until Thursday? (asking politely)

B. must not or do not have to?

1. You _____ open a power supply. It is dangerous.
2. You _____ be quick. Take all afternoon if you need it.
3. You _____ open a machine that is under warranty.
4. You _____ label the box, but everybody does.

C. Put it in the past:

1. I must replace the fan. → Yesterday I _____ the fan.
2. She can repair it. → Last year she _____ it.
3. They should check the fan. (but they did not) → They _____ the fan.

D. Present perfect simple, or continuous?

1. The log _____ (be) on the cupboard since the bench opened.
2. They _____ (repair) laptops all afternoon.
3. She _____ (know) the answer since Tuesday.
4. He _____ (clean) that fan for twenty minutes.